

Executive Summary (Together)

This report shows the development failures of Anthem, the 2019 video game developed by BioWare. Despite the immense experience, funding, and high expectations, the project was a failure, having met only a few of the goals it had set for itself. This report examines the breakdown of communication, collaboration, and leadership challenges within the development process of Anthem. A key finding is that Anthem lacked clarity and vision regarding the project. Throughout the game's development, changes were made frequently, causing developers to rush or leave features incomplete. This had everyone perplexed, reducing the efficiency of the development. Poor communication was another significant factor in Anthem's failure; developers lacked awareness of what the other sections were working on, resulting in duplication and wasted effort. This, combined with inconsistent leadership, led to unclear decisions and caused people to be uncertain about what was a priority and what was not. Based on the findings from this report, it recommends establishing a clear pathway and vision from the start of the project, supported by strong leadership. It also suggests establishing structured communication practices with regular check-ins and updates, thereby improving feedback. Refinement of features throughout production is also necessary to maintain a consistently high level of quality. In general, the failure of Anthem demonstrates that even with all the available resources, a project can still fail without strong communication and leadership. It is a key lesson that groups starting a new project should take to heart. It's not only about technical skills, but also about effective collaboration across the team as a whole. This highlights that a project's success depends not on the funding or technical expertise, but on the shared vision and communication a team has. Maintaining consistent leadership throughout the entire process of development. It also demonstrates that early issues that are not addressed can become large-scale problems. It's best to have a conversation when unsure about something instead of affecting the quality

and stability of the project as a whole. This reduces the risk and increases the chances of the project being a success.

Introduction (Jayden)

<https://kotaku.com/how-biowares-anthem-went-wrong-1833731964>

<https://screenrant.com/bioware-anthem-develop-before-destiny/>

The video game Anthem, was released in 2019 by BioWare and published by Electronic Arts, which was released with the intentions of being a new major openworld multiplayer title. Announced with significant hype and backed up by a well known studio known for their successful games like Baldur's Gate, Mass Effect, and Star Wars series. However upon Anthem's release, the game was widely criticised for technical issues, lack of unique content and inconsistencies in design, all these resulting in overwhelming disappointment and long term reputational damage for the companies involved.

Anthem's failures are significant not only because of the insanely high development costs and the industry's reputation, but also highlights how large scale software projects can fall apart and collapse despite having all the resources and skilled developers they need. Anthem failed not due to a technical issue but mainly due to the team's organisation and communication. Making it a valuable study on understanding the major impact a team's dynamic and worklife can have on complex projects.

The following report will focus mainly on the communication breakdown, and collaborative challenges. Examining how unclear direction, lack of clear vision, and poor leadership created an environment where teams couldn't coordinate effectively. By breaking down these factors, this report will aim to identify points of failures, lessons to learn and provide recommendations

for improving communication and collaboration, which we can use in future software development projects.

Background (shira)

Anthem first became known officially in 2017, during the annual E3 convention. Although developers initially started working on the game in 2012, right after finishing *Mass Effect 3*.

Originally the game Anthem had a different name. They had been planning to go with the name '*Beyond*'. This name had more representation and meaning behind it, with the saying 'you'd go out *Beyond* the walls of your fort and into the dangerous wilds around you'. But ended up switching to Anthem as securing the rights to the trademark would have been too difficult.

Whereas Anthem doesn't have much of a meaning behind it. Later on a meaning behind the name Anthem was come up with. "The game's planet was enveloped by something called the Anthem of Creation, a powerful, mysterious force that left environmental cataclysms across the world." (Kotaku 2019).

Earlier ideas for Anthem were ambitious and were constantly changing. Apparently nobody working on the game actually knew what the game would look like by the end. One of the main goals was to break away from their traditional sci-fi and fantasy, in order to feel different from *Mass Effect* and *Dragon Age*. One of the concepts that came up was the thought of a dangerous, hazard-filled planet.

In August of 2014, the game lost their leader, Casey Hudson. He had directed the game *Mass Effect* and was supposed to be the creative director on Anthem. "The foundation of our new IP in Edmonton is complete," he wrote in a letter to the studio (Kotaku 2019). A relatively new hire, Jon Warner, took on the role of game director. With the new lead and more developers joining the production, the full team reported with high hopes and ambitious ideas. Quickly comparing

how much better the ones working on Anthem had it, then the ones who were stuck on Mass Effect: Andromeda, which was going through major struggles.

Analysis of Contributing Factors (Jacob)

Many factors contributed to the failure of Anthem, chief among them was communication. There was a lack of communication that resulted in a lack of direction, the developers wanted the game to go a different direction than the game director wanted. However not all of the game directors ideas were clearly communicated to the team. In a 2019 article by Kotaku an anonymous employee stated, “There was a lot of resistance from the team who just didn’t want to see a sci-fi Dragon Age” (Kotaku 2019). In contrast David Gaider, a veteran Bioware writer, said in an email that when he’d started on the project, Anthem design director Preston Watamaniuk had pushed him in a “science-fantasy” direction (Kotaku 2019). In that same article Gaider commented “It was clear from the outset that there was a lot of opposition to the change from the rest of the team... Maybe they assumed the idea for it came from me” (Kotaku 2019). That displays an uncertainty if the rest of the team was aware in the change of direction and it’s clear the team was not unified in the direction the game was pushed. Gaider would later leave the team and the game’s story would undergo a “total story reboot”. Another developer commented, “As you can imagine, writing for BioWare sets the foundation for all the games... When writing is unsure of what it’s doing, it causes a lot of destruction to a lot of departments” (Kotaku 2019).

Another communication issue came from the Frostbite game engine they were using. As one developer expressed, “Frostbite is like an in-house engine with all the problems that entails—it’s poorly documented, hacked together, and so on—with all the problems of an externally sourced

engine” (Kotaku 2019). They further commented, “nobody you actually work with designed it, so you don’t know why this thing works the way it does, why this is named the way it is” (Kotaku 2019). That creates an environment rife for communication issues and it’s clear the team needed more precise expertise on the engine they clearly didn’t have and didn’t receive. However the decision to use that same engine came from the same place they could give them that assistance: EA, their parent company. At one point EA even reassigned some of their more experienced engineers who had better learned the Frostbite as one developer divulged, “A lot of the really talented engineers were actually working on FIFA when they should’ve been working on Anthem” (Kotaku 2019).

Additionally there was a clear power dynamic as commented by another developer, “The amount of support you’d get at EA on Frostbite is based on how much money your studio’s game is going to make” (Kotaku 2019). They couldn’t get the support they needed to build the game and when they got some level of expertise some of their manpower was allocated elsewhere. Leadership also created some team dynamic issues, they were against discussing “Destiny” and would react negatively to any comparisons (Kotaku 2019). In doing so they were making it harder for their developers as the common sentiment among them was that there was value in studying the market leader and there was value in comparison, but to the leaders it was taboo, “This isn’t Destiny,” they would say (Kotaku 2019).

It was not only the leadership, but the studio structure itself that caused power dynamics issues leading to even more lacking communication. Bioware was at the time divided into 3 teams Edmonton, Austin, and Montreal. However some members of the studio thought of Edmonton as the A-team, Austin as the B-Team, and Montreal as the C-team. So when Edmonton and Austin there was an underlying sentiment of “Edmonton understandably has the perspective of, ‘We are the original BioWare.’ Anybody not part of that brand is lesser, and does not garner the

same level of trust as people that are in the Edmonton office” (Kotaku 2019). So when Austin was brought into the project it was very clear there was a lack of a unified vision for the game as one Austin developer put it, “When Anthem was presented to us, it was never really clear what the game was” (Kotaku 2019). Austin was also assigned tasks to work on without questions. Attempts at feedback or suggestions were often ignored or dismissed by the Edmonton team (Kotaku 2019). In other words the Edmonton team were abusing their perceived power and were pushing their direction even though it was clear even among the Edmonton team that there was no clear direction. It’s evident somewhere along the line communication had broken down and attempts to create a unified vision had failed.

Lessons Learned (Cody)

<https://kotaku.com/how-biowares-anthem-went-wrong-1833731964>

<https://blog.bioware.com/2019/04/02/anthem-game-development/>

The failure of Anthem shows how important communication, teamwork, and leadership are in large software projects. Even though BioWare and Electronic Arts had the resources and experienced developers, the project still struggled because the team was not properly aligned. A big takeaway is that having skilled people isn’t enough if they aren’t all working toward the same goal (Kotaku, 2019).

One of the main lessons is the need for a clear vision from the start. Throughout development, the team didn’t fully know what kind of game they were making until very late. This made it hard for different teams to stay on track and caused a lot of rework. Looking at Tuckman’s stages of group development, the team never really got past the early stages where everyone agrees on goals and roles. Because of that, they stayed stuck in confusion and disagreement instead of moving forward smoothly.

Another important lesson is the need for consistent and open communication. Developers often didn't know what others were working on or what direction they were supposed to follow (Kotaku, 2019). This led to wasted time and frustration. Simple things like regular updates, clearer documentation, and actually listening to feedback could have helped keep everyone on the same page.

The project also shows how power dynamics can hurt teamwork. Some teams, especially outside the main studio, felt like their ideas were ignored or not taken seriously (Kotaku, 2019). This connects to the power and influence model, where certain groups have more control and others don't get as much say. Because of this, useful feedback was missed and problems weren't caught early.

Leadership was another major issue. There wasn't a strong consistent direction, and leadership didn't always accept feedback from the team (Kotaku, 2019; BioWare, 2019). This caused confusion and constant changes during development. A stronger leadership approach with clearer decisions and better communication would have helped keep the project more organized.

Lastly, the issues with the Frostbite engine show how important technical communication is. Developers struggled because the engine wasn't well documented and they didn't always have the support they needed (Kotaku, 2019). This made development slower and more difficult than it needed to be.

Overall, Anthem teaches that clear communication, a shared vision, and good leadership are key to making a project successful. Without those, even a well-funded and experienced team can struggle to deliver a good final product.

Recommendations (Azam)

There were a couple of recommendations that could have been given after the failure of Anthem. A major issue was the lack of clarity in decision-making during the game's creation. Many of the developers were unsure of the direction the game was heading because it was changing so frequently. "It wasn't even clear what kind of game *Anthem* even was until that E3 demo in June of 2017, less than two years before it actually came out." This caused features to be incomplete and rushed. Developers often had no idea what their coworkers were working on. This caused mass confusion. A recommendation is to organize a clear pathway early on and communicate any problems or changes that are being made. Additionally, holding regular meetings and providing updates ensures everyone is aligned. An Example can be seen in what Riot Games does, where they have daily check-ins where at "10am standup, a quick huddle with the other engineers where [they] find out what everybody is up to and help out where needed." This adds more clarity and prevents issues from building up internally. Inside a work environment, it should be encouraged to speak about issues you're facing early. Instead of letting it build up and creating a massive one. The third major issue was having the major features left until the end of development. In Anthem, this made the work quality sloppy and poor. A better approach would be to test the work thoroughly and improve throughout the development of the game; it would have increased the results and fixed the bugs more efficiently. It also reduces the stress on the developers, allowing the workload to be more achievable across the entirety of the development. A fourth issue was the weak leadership; it was unclear who was leading the project, and this created consistent skepticism throughout the development of Anthem, with the workers not really sure who was in charge, creating an inconsistency with what was expected. A recommendation would be establishing clear leadership accountability. This would've helped prevent mixed ideas on the project by ensuring everyone is working towards the same outcome fully until the end of the development. In total the recommendations directly address the communication issues and failure to work as a team,

leadership challenges contributing to the downfall of anthem as a whole. Implementing a clearer vision plan, with communication practices, open feedback, and stronger leadership, can significantly reduce the risk of a major failure like this one in future projects.

Conclusion (jayden)

The failure of Anthem demonstrates how even well supported and highly anticipated projects can collapse when communication, collaboration, and leadership are not effectively managed. Despite being developed by a big company like BioWare, the project struggled due to a lack of clear direction, inconsistent decision-making, and poor coordination between teams. These issues created mass confusion across teams, leading to wasted time, and which ultimately resulted in a mass disappointment of a project.

This report has shown that the challenges faced during Anthem's development were not only technical skill issues, but organisational and communication failure prevented teams from coming together and created a well developed project. As conflicts between studios limited collaboration and reduced the effectiveness of feedback given. Additionally, poor leadership made it difficult to establish development plans and maintain stability throughout the development process. As a result, small issues were left unresolved and grew into major problems over time.

The lessons analysed from these cases reinforce the importance of establishing a clear plan before starting, maintaining an open and clear communication between teams, and the importance of creating a team environment where all members feel heard. Ultimately a strong leadership and structured plans are essential to keeping large projects on track to completion. In conclusion, the downfall of Anthem serves as a great example for software teams, as it highlights that skill and financial resources alone are not enough to guarantee success in a

team. Instead what is needed is effective teamwork, clear communication, and strong leadership. By analysing and applying these lessons, future software development teams can reduce risk and improve their chances of delivering their intended project.

References

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